2 Understanding digital identity

This chapter covers

- How identity supports digital relationships
- Why naming matters for authorization
- What centralized, federated, and decentralized models are
- Tradeoffs among privacy, authenticity, and confidentiality
- Why trust and confidence both matter

Imagine you're a regular at a neighborhood café. Every morning, you walk in and the barista greets you by name. She remembers your usual order—a double espresso, no sugar. This recognition isn't just about knowing your name; it's about the relationship you've built through repeated interactions.

One day, the café switches to a new self-service kiosk for ordering. The machine doesn't know you, and it doesn't remember your order. It asks you to sign up, create an account, and log in. Suddenly, the familiar experience of being recognized is gone, replaced by a system that knows you only through an identifier and a set of attributes.

What changed? Your identity at the café was once relational and human, tied to memory, interaction, and trust. Now, in the digital system, you have been reduced to credentials and stored preferences. The system recognizes your account, not *you*. Depending on its sophistication, the digital system may give the impression it knows you, but its *personalization* efforts will often fall short. This scenario illustrates a fundamental question in digital identity: Are we just a set of attributes, or does identity mean something more?

As we explore digital identity, we'll see that it's not just about logging in or proving who you are—it's about how systems recognize, remember, and relate to people, organizations, and digital entities. And, ultimately, it's about the relationships we form in digital spaces.